



OFF-SIDE

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INDIAN SPORT NEEDS INSTITUTIONS, NOT JUST TEAMS

India's sports boom, led by the IPL, has created powerful franchises but not lasting institutions. The next phase must build multi-sport, city-rooted **ecosystems.**

In my last column, I wrote that the soaring valuations of Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Rajasthan Royals were less a triumph of Indian sport and more a triumph of one sport. But perhaps, the larger question lies beyond valuation: what comes after the franchise boom?

Because while India has spent the last decade trying to replicate the IPL, many of the world's mature sporting cultures have spent the last century building something more durable.

A franchise can win titles, sell sponsorships and command television ratings. But sporting institutions shape a city, develop generations of athletes and survive cycles of victory and defeat. India has many of the former, but it needs more of the latter.

If you are ever in Barcelona, you will quickly understand that FC Barcelona is not merely a football club. It is a cultural identity. The same crest lives across basketball, women's football, handball, futsal and youth sport. Real Madrid, for all its global glamour, follows a similar pattern. Olympiacos in Greece, Fenerbahce in Turkey and Sporting CP in Portugal are not simply clubs but social organisms of their cities.

They live by a simple maxim: one badge, many sports; one fan base, many emotional entry points.

The model compounds powerfully. A child may enter through basketball and stay for football. A sponsor may buy one property and inherit five. A city remains engaged across the calendar, not merely during a single league window.

Despite the astronomical success of the IPL, and the more modest gains made by the Pro Kabaddi League, Women's Premier League, Hockey India League and the Indian Super League, much of Indian sport remains event-led rather than institution-driven.

Every year, IPL teams appear, compete, market themselves for a few months and then recede from public consciousness. Fan engagement is intense but episodic. Sponsorship is sold season by season. Youth pathways remain peripheral, and cities host teams without fully owning them.

If the first wave of sports investment in India was about buying a franchise and entering a league, the next wave should focus on building permanent sporting institutions that are deeply integrated into cities.